

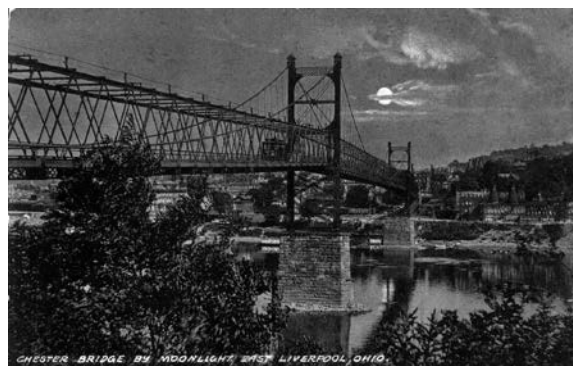
Chapter 7

The Lincoln Highway in West Virginia

The rerouting of the Lincoln Highway into West Virginia was an unintentional byproduct of bad roads in Pennsylvania. Traditionally, there were three main roads west from Pittsburgh, and the road to East Liverpool, Ohio, via Chester, West Virginia, was not among them. Pre-Lincoln Highway travelers either went southwest toward Wheeling, picking up the National Road in Washington; went west on the Steubenville Pike to Steubenville, Ohio by way of Weirton, West Virginia; or went northwest down the Ohio River and up Beaver Valley to Cleveland by way of Salem or Youngstown, Ohio. The overland travelers desiring to go to East Liverpool from Pittsburgh followed the Cleveland road to Beaver, and then struck west over poorly maintained local routes. This was essentially the route followed by the original Lincoln Highway, which opted for the higher, and drier Tuscarawas Road rather than the Midland Road along the Ohio River. It was nonetheless, the least bad of the poor choices available.

The Lincoln Highway Association's dissatisfaction with the route west from Pittsburgh was apparent in 1923 when they established an official detour away from the Tuscarawas Road and East Liverpool. Lincoln Highway traffic between Rochester, Pennsylvania and Canton, Ohio, was diverted through Beaver Falls, Salem and Alliance until a better route could be built south of the Ohio River.¹ The association also advised Lincoln Highway travelers to avoid the congested river towns on the north shore of the Ohio, by following a longer route through McKees Rocks and Monaca on the left bank.²

The greatest stumbling block to securing and improving a more direct route to East Liverpool was that none of the country lanes meandering across the farmland between the Ohio River and Steubenville Pike were part of the Pennsylvania State Highway System, and were therefore ineligible for state funds. Lincoln Highway Association consuls were eventually successful in getting a route designated and then constructed as a state highway by 1927. The new road angled northwest from Steubenville Pike at Imperial, passing through Clinton, and five miles of West Virginia Panhandle to cross the Ohio River into East Liverpool.



In 1927, the Lincoln Highway was rerouted through the northern tip of the West Virginia Panhandle, and over the 1897 Chester Bridge spanning the Ohio River.

From the Pennsylvania Line, West Virginia's Lincoln Highway descended a treacherous hill infamous for its frequent accidents,³ and then entered the river town of Chester. The route originally followed Carolina Avenue to Third Street to Virginia Avenue to First Street. A year later, it was marked with the concrete posts memorializing Abraham Lincoln. Amazingly, three posts still stand,

constituting the highest density of concrete Lincoln Highway markers in the country. In 1938, a new bridge connected First Street directly with Carolina Avenue. The Lincoln Highway originally crossed the Ohio River from First Street, over what was known as both the Chester Bridge and the Lincoln Highway Bridge. Built in 1897, the 705-foot suspension bridge was demolished in 1970.⁴ Traffic was diverted over the nearby Newell Bridge until the Jennings-Randolph Bridge was opened in 1977.



Closed, neglected, and slated for destruction in 1984, the Chester Teapot was saved, moved and restored by the borough of Chester.

Lincoln Highway Preservation in West Virginia

For such a small state, West Virginia has some significant Lincoln Highway landmarks, including three 1928 concrete markers, and the famous Chester Teapot. The Teapot began its life as a Hire's Root Beer Barrel purchased in Pennsylvania by William Devon in 1938. Devon carted it to Chester's Carolina Avenue, which was by then part of the Lincoln Highway, and crafted a spout, handle and lid to convert the barrel into a teapot from which he sold pottery. By the 1970s, this wonderful example of mimetic roadside architecture was abandoned and in a state of disrepair. It was moved from its lot when the property was sold in 1984, and restored by the borough of Chester in 1990.⁵ It currently sits on Carolina Avenue at the eastern end of the Jennings-Randolph Bridge.

¹ Lincoln Highway Association, *A Complete Official Guide to the Lincoln Highway*, Detroit: Lincoln Highway Association, 1924, 252.

² Lincoln Highway Association, 1924, 249.

³ Butko, Brian A. *Pennsylvania Traveler's Guide: The Lincoln Highway*, Mechanicsburg, PA: Stackpole Books, 1996, 300.

⁴ Plowden, David, *Bridges: The Spans of North America*, New York: W. W. Norton and Co. 1974, 207.

⁵ Jourdan, Katherine M. "Another Roadside Attraction: The Chester Teapot," *Goldenseal*, Volume 17, Number 1, Spring 1991.